



MAKE THE BIRDS WORK FOR YOU!

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This is the board game that won the Kennerspiel des Jahres in 2019, the top award for board games and translates to "connoisseur/expert game of the year". In a market saturated with games about European expansionism (Azul, Carcassonne, Puerto Rico, 7 Wonders, Catan), this is a decidedly woke game about nature and the environment. The gameplay involves building up an ecosystem by crafting chain reactions, or cascades. You get to draft and use a beautiful deck of birds, and you get to learn about their habitats, the food they eat, the type of nests they lay, how many eggs they lay in each nest, and of course, their wingspans. All of these combined with their special powers help build up your ecosystem, or "engine". In September 2020, Wingspan released a version on Steam.

The birds on the cards are animated, has recordings of the calls of the actual birds, and when you pick a bird a "fun fact" about the bird is read out, typically something that makes the creature unique or interesting.

GAMEPLAY

You have to draft birds first. Normally you get a selection of birds to start with, that you need to consider a few things. The most important thing are the powers or abilities of the birds. There are many kinds of powers, most work at that turn, some allow you to tuck cards or stack food providing extra points, some work between turns, and some may benefit others as well, so be wary of the cards that you pick! The really great thing here is that the birds you pick and the way you build your engine affects the other engines and the birds they play.

It is necessary to look at the type of food that has fallen in the food tray, you need to pick them up and spend them to place the birds. You have to spend the food tokens to get the bird cards, so be sure that the cards picked can be purchased with the

food tokens kept. You can spend

corn to draft a bird that needs a worm, but you need to spend the worm to put the bird into play. Keep an eye out on the round goal, which may be birds with a particular type of nest, or birds in a particular habitat. After

drafting the birds, you get a goal card, which is your own personal bonus that applies for the entire duration of the game. You need to focus on round goals, personal goals, and gaining the most points during every turn. While you are unlikely to run out of eggs, it is good to keep out for at least one of those cards with five or seven eggs that give you "egg security", and not have to worry about running out of birds that can lay eggs.

The game consists of 4 rounds with eight turns each. At each turn, you can activate one of the three habitats for an action associated with that habitat, for example draft a card in the water habitat, lay eggs in the ground habitat, or forage food in the forest habitat. Alternatively, you can put a card into play into any of the habitats. The more cards you have in play at a habitat, the more benefits you get for the action associated with that habitat, for example, you can get more food, lay more eggs, or draft more birds. The more birds you put in play, the more points you get. To place birds, you need to lay eggs on birds, some birds can lay only one or two eggs, but a few can hold larger clutches. The cycle is essentially draft birds, gather food, play birds, lay eggs and repeat.

The main thing here is the turn order and managing the resources. Note that every time you choose a particular turn, all the powers of all the birds in that habitat are triggered in sequence. There are a lot of birds with a lot of powers, and it is hard to